



Rattan bindings

Habaki (soft metal collar) to transmit the shock of a blow to the shaft

Hardened cutting edge

▲ NAGINATA

Date 19th century

Origin Japan

Weight 1.95kg (4¼lb)

Length 2.75m (9ft)

Naginata blades, mounted on oval wooden shafts about 2m (6½ft) long, were the standard weapon of foot soldiers in medieval Japan. Used as a spear or a fighting staff, they were especially associated with warrior monks, the *sōhei*.



Breech

Loops for attaching gun to support

Touch-hole

Barrel decorated with a dragon in silver

Muzzle

◀ CHINESE SILK GUN

Date c.1825

Origin China

Weight 1.42kg (3lb)

Length 83.2cm (37¼in)

Calibre 63.5mm

This cannon, designed for portability, was made from a copper tube wrapped with iron wire and silk cord. It derived from earlier guns, which were made from bamboo wound with cord. Chinese paintings show soldiers lying on the battlefield firing similar guns.



Stock of red oak

Ramrod

Decorative expanded muzzle

► TSUKUBO

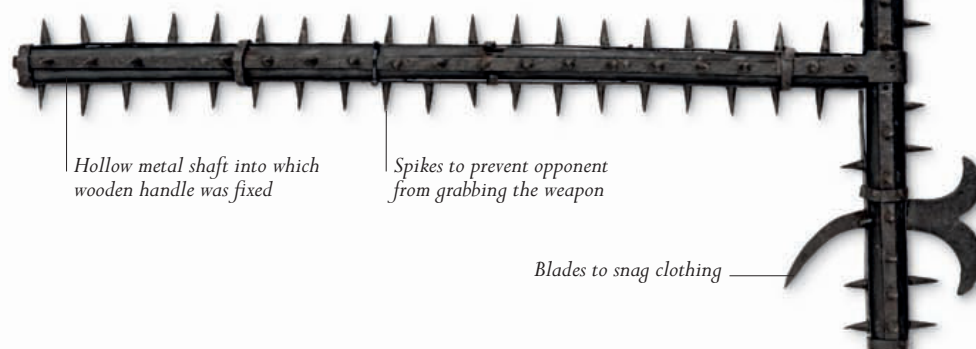
Date 19th century

Origin Japan

Weight 1.36kg (3lb)

Length 69cm (27¼in)

Although not principally a weapon of war, implements such as this *tsukubo* (pushing pole) were used to overcome and detain criminals in Japan. In towns and cities, racks of these devices were positioned at strategic sites for use by law enforcement officers.



Hollow metal shaft into which wooden handle was fixed

Spikes to prevent opponent from grabbing the weapon

Blades to snag clothing



Red-painted stock

▲ CHINESE MATCHLOCK

Date c.1830

Origin China

Weight 8.6kg (19lb)

Barrel 1.6m (5¼ft)

Calibre 15mm

Unlike the matchlocks used in Japan, on most Chinese guns the match-holder and trigger are one piece, so that when the trigger is pulled up, the match-holder dips down to apply the flame to the touch-hole. This is a simple, functional example, undecorated save for the stock, which is painted red.

▼ JAPANESE PILL-LOCK CARBINE

Date c.1850

Origin Japan

Weight 3.64kg (8lb)

Barrel 67cm (26¼in)

Calibre 12.5mm

In 1853, American warships forced Japan to open its ports for trade, introducing new technology. Within a few years, the Japanese had adopted percussion ignition for their guns. This example has an automatic dispenser for detonating pills (its ignition primers).



Barrel

Magazine for detonating pills

"Captive" ramrod, permanently fixed to gun to avoid loss